AMERICA - SHORT HISTORY

Indigenous people of North America

- They formed many diverse communities and tribes all over the continent

- Some of them ware hunter-gatherers and some lived a sedentary lifestyle

- Number of them has dropped after Europeans have arrived mainly because:

  - Europeans brought disseizes which killed the natives
  - Native Americans ware killed by European colonizers

- Many Indigenous people resisted and continue to preserve their culture today

Jamestown

- It was the first permanent English settlement in what later became United States

- Was founded in **1607** by the Virginia company

- It faced many problems including disease, hunger and conflict with native people

- It survived and became the first successful English colony

Manifest destiny

- It was a belief that the US was destined to conquered the American continent and that the settlers had received the right to do so from God

- Fuelled later wars and the idea of a “greater America”

American War of Independence (1775-83)

- Colonies fought against the British rule to gain independence from them

- Key causes:

  - Opposition to British taxation imposed on Americans combined with the lack of their representation in the British parliament
  - Desire for self-government

- As a result America became an independent country

Declaration of independence (1776)

- Announced the colonies’ independence from Britain

- Stated that all people have natural rights like life, liberty and pursuit of happiness

- Influenced democratic movements worldwide

The Constitution (1787) and Bill of rights (1791)

- The constitution set up the federal government and the system of checks and balances

- The bill of rights contained the first 10 amendments protecting individual liberties

The most important amendments

- Amendments of the constitution ware introduced in order to adapt the law to the changing needs of the country and its citizens and to fix what couldn't have been done properly at the time of its original drafting

- 13th – abolished slavery

- 15th – voting rights regardless of race

- 19th – women's suffrage

- 21st – ended prohibition

- 2nd – allows Americans to bear arms and form militias

The civil war (1861-1856)

- It was a military conflict between the southern and northern states

- Main issues ware slavery and the future of the union

- It resulted in abolishing slavery and a stronger federal government

The great depression (1929-1939)

- It was a severe economic crisis resulting in unemployment, bank failures and poverty

- Led to the introduction of The New Deal

- It changed the role if state in the economy

The civil rights movement

- It ended segregation

- Key achievements:

  - Civil Rights Act
  - Voting Rights Act

- Most important people associated with this movement ware:

  - Martin Luther King Jr.
  - Rosa Parks (from the bus incident)
  - Malcolm X
  - John Lewis

The Cold War (1947-1991)

- It was an indirect conflict between the western bloc led by the US and the eastern bloc led by the USSR

- It included proxy wars, nuclear arms race and the space race

The second amendment & The Colt revolver

- The second amendment gave right for American citizens to bear arms and form militias

- The colt revolver helped popularise guns in America also being the first firearm to bring such firepower

- Militias are armed groups, often organized locally (today some are very controversial)

The NRA (National Rifle Association)

- An association that advocates for gun rights and heavily influences firearm policy in the US

Lockheed Martin

- An aerospace and defence company

- Plays a key role in US and global military equipment industry

Most important US interventions in other countries

- Vietnam

- Iraq

- Afghanistan

- Serbia/Kosovo

- Korea